to link those Indian Ocean/Iranian logistic points to China via modern railways and highways, this could very significantly alter the balance of naval power in the Indian Ocean. This could severely diminish India's security against Chinese encirclement.

India and the Sino–Iranian comprehensive strategic partnership

Commentary in India's media reflected Indian concern with the deepening of the China–Iran partnership. A long analysis of Xi's January 2016 mission to Tehran in *The Hindu* newspaper maintained that Beijing "is actually playing a long game in West Asia" in courting Tehran.[17] China had decided to act as a regional power in West Asia and take a more "pro-active" approach that suits the country's big power ambitions, journalist Stanly Johny said. Xi's visit to Tehran was a manifestation of this new, more assertive approach. Beijing carefully framed Xi's visit in terms of mere economic cooperation, Johny said, but "the real focus of the visit was not lost on anyone." Xi's visit opened a "new season" of strategic cooperation that included intelligence sharing, military exchanges, and counter-terrorism. Iran was the most stable country in the region and "the only major country in West Asia where the United States has practically no influence." It was only natural for China to use closer ties with Iran to respond to the US pivot to East Asia, Johny said. The journalist noted the effectiveness of China's earlier use of Western sanctions on Iran to seize opportunities to replace Western countries as Iran's key economic partners and lamented India's failure "to retain the balance between Western pressure and ties with Iran during the [post 2003] sanctions era." Now Xi was using that recently accrued